the position it had always enjoyed in its long history. This conveys a certain historical inevitability about China's emergence as an uncontested superpower. The more complex saga that is outlined in Chapter 1, with all its jagged edges and sharp twists and turns, has been transformed into an unbroken and steady advance towards a manifest destiny of untrammelled power and influence.

Stories that countries tell about themselves are important to help us understand their external behaviour. The Chinese call this having 'discourse power'. A persuasive narrative enables the pursuit of power to be cloaked in a mantle of legitimacy. China, it is claimed, has always been a great power in history, and its power and influence were acknowledged by other states which engaged with it.

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There are other important props in this story which must be understood in analysing Chinese behaviour, and the so-called tribute system is one such artifice. As I mentioned briefly in the Introduction, there were periods when China was ruled by strong and extensive empires, some Han, others non-Han. There were other periods of weakened and multiple political dispensations struggling to survive. During the phases of a strong centralized empire in China, neighbouring states and maritime kingdoms sought trade relations with China and some acknowledged the overlordship of the Chinese emperor, even though this may have been more ritualistic rather than acknowledgement of actual vassal status. There were several phases when a weakened China itself became a tributary to hostile tribal kingdoms on its periphery, buying peace through the offer of gold and luxury goods like silk and porcelain. The political use of the practice of offering and receiving gifts is not unique to China and continues to this day in international diplomacy. What is different is the manner in which the tribute system became a symbol of China's view of itself as a celestial empire at the centre of the world and a source of political legitimacy.

This has its origin in the production of the Illustrations of Tributary States by Emperor Yuan of the Liang dynasty in the mid-sixth century CE , with